



feature

The D700 is Nikon's cheapest full frame camera and boasts of terrific low light performance

carefully packed the Nikkor 18-200-mm lens I bought last year. Priced at Rs. 25,000, this long zoom lens can be used on all Nikon DSLR DX (ie. not FX format) cameras and allows for great versatility for distance and close-range shooting.

The standard 18-55-mm lens that ships with the D60 was also packed. Next I removed and backed up the 8-GB SD card that was inside the camera and emptied it. I also had an empty, identical spare and both cards were packed along with the camera. I had no intention of running out of space to shoot; it's happened before and isn't funny, I assure you. These cards are SanDisk eXtreme III SD cards and offer write speeds of up to 30 MBps, very suitable for high-end cameras and professionals swear by these cards. Such a card will set you back by Rs. 1,500 — expensive but they're worth the premium. 16-GB SD cards can be had for as little as Rs. 2,600 and are suitable if you want to shoot videos as well. Next I packed my Canon PowerShot A710IS with the new batteries. This beauty has been a trustworthy companion over the past two years she's been with me. What I love the most is her ability to deliver good night-time shots and her low-light performance is very decent. Optical image stabilisation takes care of blur-causing camera shake and she's got a 6x optical zoom. She's not truly pocketable, thanks to her curvaceous grip, but this makes for a firm hold. If you must have a compact, pocketable camera look at Canon's Digital IXUS series — the Digital IXUS 80IS is good. It's really compact and takes quality photos. I packed my camcorder next. I have a Panasonic SDR-H40GC-S. This camcorder features a 42x optical zoom and a 40-GB hard drive. What I really like about the model is the effectiveness of the image stabilisation unit — even at the long end of the zoom there's no visible blur. I prefer hard-drive based camcorders above other media any day. These start up and record faster with fewer delays and one saves on the cost of disks and tapes. When shooting outdoors, the huge optical zoom does make a difference, allow-



Grado SR 225 — Entry-level audiophile joy

ing one to capture even distant scenery rather well. Priced at just Rs. 25,000 the SDR-H40GC-S is definitely worth a look for someone looking to buy a camcorder. Thus concluded the packing of what I



Creative EP630 — Affordable, good sounding in-ears

fondly call my *memory-makers*, cameras, camcorders and their ilk.

Some of the other stuff I had to pack is used daily, either in the office, or at home or the gym, so I made a note lest I forget to pack them later. I'd carry my iPod Touch with me for sure. With no introduction necessary, this wonderful PMP is a must try for everyone. Apple's multi-touch interface is nothing short of amazing. It's got great sound quality and the screen is clear and crisp — a joy for viewing images and movies alike. I made sure to carefully pack both USB and mains chargers. I also threw in my in-ear

Creative EP630 earplugs for use whilst commuting. For a mere 800 bucks these earplugs are a steal and offer decent sound quality with slightly overemphasised bass. A good buy for anyone looking at portability and good noise isolation. My Grado SR 225 supra-aural headphones would also accompany me for I cannot survive for very long without these beauties pampering my aural senses with their lovely sonic embrace and I'm bereft whenever we part. Besides, being extremely lightweight and robust they have an amazingly rich musical presentation and

although not the most neutral of cans, the mid-range is superb. The highs are extended, although not harsh, and the bass, while not as deep as some, has good impact. Unfortunately, the SR 225s are not available in India, but you can check them out at www.gradolabs.com. With a lot of my gear laid out and notes made on most of what I'd be carrying I decided to call it a day.

Thursday — Oh weekend, where art thou?

After wrapping up work, I took a little time off to check up on the area around Shimla. There's a wealth of information online. It seems there are local guides available to take one around and there are lots of places to stay. There were several inns and hotels that allowed online bookings. The editor dropped by my desk and told me to carry my notebook along with me, and more importantly to check (and reply to) important mails. Not that I'm averse to packing a notebook, in fact I am not one of those people who can make do solely with a PDA — they aren't productive enough for me — and I hate cramped keyboards. I have an Apple Macbook 2008 with 4 GB of DDR3 RAM running OS X 10.5.6, with Windows XP Pro co-existing peacefully thanks to Boot Camp. It's a compact notebook with a screen size of 13.3 inches. For those looking at something really compact yet reasonably powerful, look at the 12.1-inch screen size. 11.1-inch notebooks are also available but I also packed my trusty old Reliance data card with me. Although it's an ancient CDMA 1x unit with a super-slow 56.6 kbps connection, I stick with it as it's enough



Apple Macbook 2008 — Sleek shell, superb performer